

Filing the email — or understanding it

How iManage, NetDocuments, Worldox and ZERO handle email filing, mapped against Spaarke's Association Engine — the same underlying jobs, approached from the opposite end of the pipe, plus a short list of gaps worth closing.

The one-sentence version

The incumbents make **filing a client-side action the user performs** — prompt on send, pick a location, drop a token in the subject line. Spaarke makes **association a server-side decision the system performs** — every message that reaches a monitored mailbox is captured, run through a multi-signal engine, and either auto-filed or queued for one-click review, with a full audit trail of *why*.

That inversion means we are **already ahead** on automation, auditability, delegate handling, offline/mobile/OWA coverage, and data model — and it makes their signature feature, "*predict the folder*," just one rung of our ladder. It also produces four specific, cheap-to-close gaps: **per-matter file-to addresses**, **cross-mailbox dedupe**, **engine suggestions surfaced inside Outlook**, and an optional **send-time nudge**. And it lets us do one thing neither competitor does at all — **make the matter record current from the email's contents**, not just store the email next to it.

FRAMING

Two philosophies of "getting the email on the matter"

Every feature below is a variation on one of these two centers of gravity. Naming them makes the rest of the comparison fall into place.

IMANAGE · NETDOCUMENTS · WORLDFOX

Client-side, user-initiated, folder-centric

- The **Outlook add-in is the product**. Filing happens in the mail client, at the user's hand.
- A **prediction suggests a destination**; the human confirms it (Predictive Filing, Suggested/Recent Locations).
- Thread continuity rides a **subject-line token** or a repeated prediction.
- The destination is a **folder** in a document taxonomy.
- Offline, mobile and OWA require bolting on a **server-side path** after the fact.

SPAARKE

Server-side, engine-initiated, record-centric

- The **Association Engine is the product**. Capture is a Graph subscription on the mailbox — no client dependency.
- A **ladder of rungs** (explicit reference, thread, participant, attachment, name, semantic, AI) reinforces into a confidence score and a **Resolved / Suggested / Ambiguous** decision.
- Thread continuity rides **RFC message-id ancestry** — no subject pollution.
- The destination is a **typed record** — matter, project, invoice, service request, event ... (12 regarding types).
- Offline, mobile and OWA are **inherent** — delivery to Exchange is the trigger, not the client.

USE-CASE BY USE-CASE

The five jobs, and how we'd win each

Taking the competitor write-up's own categories in turn: what they do, what Spaarke ships today (grounded in the code), an honest verdict, and the move that reaches parity or beyond.

MANUAL FILING

Send & File · Browse & File · Predictive Filing

● Ahead on automation · gap in Outlook

iManage exposes Browse-and-File from the ribbon and Send-and-File on compose, drawing on Suggested + Recent Locations. NetDocuments' ndMail adds web-scale Predictive Filing. In both, the human is in the loop *at the client*, picking from ranked destinations.

THEM

Prediction ranks folders; user confirms in Outlook. Strong in-client UX; the prediction is a single top suggestion.

SPAARKE TODAY

The engine auto-associates server-side (matter / project / service request auto-file; everything else surfaced). A rich review UI — candidate cards, confirm / change / link-another / create-from-email — lives in the `CommunicationConnections` form modal and the r5 `EmailWorkspace`. A real Outlook add-in ("Save to Spaarke") files manually — but it does *not* yet show the engine's suggestions.

HOW WE WIN

Pipe the engine's top-3 candidates (already computed by `derivePrimaryReview`) **into the Save-to-Spaarke task pane**. That turns our add-in into true Predictive Filing — but backed by a multi-signal ladder with an audit trail, not a black-box folder guess — and unifies it with the code-page review so a user sees the same ranked candidates everywhere.

The "luggage tag" · Inbox Filer · Conversation Filing

● Ahead · cleaner & delegate-safe

iManage appends a token to the subject line encoding firm + client.matter, so replies survive external round-trips and auto-file via Inbox Filer. It's the category's cleverest — and ugliest — trick. NetDocuments does the same job through prediction (the prior location surfaces as the top suggestion on a reply).

THEM

Subject-line token (visible clutter; survives header stripping by design). Inbox Filer has a known gap: for a **delegate's** inbox it records the mailbox owner as the filer — wrong, since assistants file a lot of partner mail.

SPAARKE TODAY

`ThreadContinuityRung` inherits the parent communication's regarding via **RFC In-Reply-To / References ancestry** — no subject token. It inherits auto-file strength *only* from a Resolved parent, so an unconfirmed guess never propagates down a thread. Filer identity is set correctly on confirm by Job B's impersonation write (`MSCRMCallerID` = the confirming user).

HOW WE WIN

We already get the clean outcome without polluting the subject, and the **delegate gap simply doesn't exist for us** — capture has no per-inbox filer identity. The one thing the token buys is surviving header-stripping external systems; we cover that case a different way — `ExplicitReference` + `RecordNameMatch` catch a matter number in the subject or body even when threading headers are gone. If a firm genuinely needs external round-trip survival, we can stamp our own regarding into a header/subject token as an *opt-in* — never the default.

Linked Folders · Filing Folders · Folder Mapping

Link an Outlook folder to a DMS folder; anything dragged in files automatically. Attractive because it rides existing habits — problematic because, as the write-up itself concedes, the Outlook tree and the DMS taxonomy drift apart.

THEM

"Drag it and forget it." Convenient muscle-memory; guaranteed taxonomy drift and per-user folder sprawl over time.

SPAARKE TODAY

No folder mapping — by design. Server-side auto-association removes the reason to hand-file into folders at all: the engine picks a *record*, so there is no Outlook-folder tree to drift.

HOW WE WIN

Position engine-driven association as the better default (no drift, no sprawl). For firms that want the muscle-memory, offer an **Outlook category** → **regarding mapping** that feeds a strong deterministic signal into the same engine — the habit is preserved, but it becomes one more rung, not a parallel filing system that rots.

Workspace email addresses (matter-12345@firm.com)

● Architecture matches · convenience gap

A per-matter address in To/Cc/Bcc auto-files to that workspace. Under the hood: a shared mailbox + transport rules + a server-side service resolving the address to a workspace ID. This is *exactly* our architecture — we just don't parse the address yet.

THEM

Bcc `matter-12345@` and it files. Simple, deterministic, loved by clients' outbound systems. Needs alias provisioning + transport rules per workspace.

SPAARKE TODAY

`GraphSubscriptionManager` already captures per monitored mailbox, server-side app-only — the shared-mailbox capture is done. Recipients (To/Cc) are modeled and `ParticipantCorrelation` resolves them via contact→membership. But nothing parses a structured `matter-{n}@` alias, and Bcc isn't modeled.

HOW WE WIN

Add a **recipient-alias rung** that reads To/Cc/Bcc for a per-matter address and emits an `ExplicitReference` - tier match — the resolver infrastructure and the ladder already exist, so this is small. Result: exact iManage parity on the file-to-address pattern, *plus* our confidence ladder and provenance on top of it. (Model Bcc while we're there.)

Client vs. server · dedupe · offline · delegates

iManage runs both client- and server-side filing; the server path is what makes offline Send-and-File, mobile and OWA work at all. NetDocuments checks whether a copy is *already filed* before uploading — the dedupe that matters because one message lands in six mailboxes.

THEM

Server-side path added to reach mobile/OWA/offline. ND dedupes on "already filed?" before upload. SoftBlock warns on send but never permanently blocks.

SPAARKE TODAY

Server-side *by architecture* — offline, mobile and OWA capture are inherent, no client needed. Dedupe is multi-layer but keys on the **per-mailbox Graph message id**; the same RFC message in two monitored mailboxes would create two rows. `sprk_internetmessageid` is captured but only used for threading.

HOW WE WIN

Add an **internet-message-id existence check on create** — we already store the field; it just isn't on the dedupe path. That gives true cross-mailbox dedupe, matching ND's "already filed?" check. On offline/mobile/OWA and delegate correctness we're already ahead and need do nothing.

AT A GLANCE

Capability matrix

The underlying capability, not the marketing name for it. "Spaarke planned" reflects the roadmap below — each item is an extension of the existing engine, not a new system.

CAPABILITY	IMANAGE	NETDOCUMENTS	SPAARKE TODAY	SPAARKE PLANNED
Server-side capture (no client dependency)	■ Add-on EWS path bolted on	■ Add-on ndMail service + EWS	■ Native Graph subscription	■ Native
Predictive destination ranking	■ Suggested/Recent	■ Predictive Filing	■ Multi-rung ladder + confidence + provenance	■ Surfaced in Outlook too

CAPABILITY	IMANAGE	NETDOCUMENTS	SPAARKE TODAY	SPAARKE PLANNED
Refuses to guess on conflicts	■ Top pick	■ Top pick	■ Ambiguous state human decides; never auto-guesses	■ Ambiguous state
Thread continuity without subject clutter	■ Subject token	■ Prediction	■ Message-id ancestry	■ + opt-in token for header-stripping paths
Per-matter file-to address	■ Workspace address	■ Yes	■ Not parsed	■ Recipient-alias rung
Cross-mailbox dedupe (6-inbox problem)	■ Partial	■ "Already filed?" check	■ Per-mailbox only	■ Internet-message-id
In-Outlook manual filing	■ Browse & File	■ ndMail	■ Save to Spaarke no suggestions in pane; quick-save stubbed	■ + ranked candidates
Send-time nudge (SoftBlock)	■ SmartAlert	■ SoftBlock	● N/A by design capture-first: nothing is "lost"	■ Optional SoftBlock
Delegate / assistant filing correctness	■ Records wrong filer	■ Varies	■ Correct impersonation write	■ Correct
Full audit trail of the filing decision	■ No	■ No	■ Provenance JSON per-rung, per-candidate	■ Provenance JSON
Destination types	■ Folders	■ Folders	■ 12 record types matter, project, invoice, SR, event...	■ 12 record types
Update the matter record from the email	■ No	■ No	■ Job B cited, confirmed, audited field updates	■ Job B

■ Have it / strong ■ Partial ■ Gap / absent ● Not applicable by design

WHERE WE ALREADY LEAD

Six advantages that fall out of the architecture

These aren't features we'd have to build to catch up — they're consequences of choosing a server-side engine over a client-side add-in, and they're hard for the incumbents to retrofit.

A Decision, not a guess

Independent rungs reinforce (bounded noisy-OR) into a confidence score, and conflicts resolve to an explicit *Ambiguous* state rather than a silent top-pick. Fewer misfiles — and when we're unsure, we say so.

B Defensible by construction

Every association writes a provenance record: which rungs fired, each candidate's confidence, what was written and why. Neither incumbent can show a client *why* an email landed where it did.

C Record-currency, not just storage

Job B reads the email and *proposes cited, human-confirmed updates to the matter record* — a new deadline, a changed contact — then writes them under audit. The incumbents file the message and stop there. This is our sharpest wedge.

D Delegate-safe, offline-native

Capture is triggered by delivery to Exchange, so mobile, OWA and offline all work with no extra path — and there's no per-inbox filer to record incorrectly for an assistant. iManage lists both as known limitations.

E Typed records, not folders

We file to a matter, project, invoice, service request or event — 12 regarding types — so the email becomes queryable, related data, not a document in a tree that drifts from the taxonomy.

F Governed and reversible

Auto-file scope, thresholds and the core record set are config-driven kill-switches — tunable per tenant without a redeploy. A misfile is re-filed under audit, never silently overwritten.

CLOSING THE GAPS

Roadmap to parity-and-beyond

Ordered by leverage. Every item extends the existing engine or the existing Outlook add-in — none is a new system — which is why the effort estimates are small.

P1

NOW

Per-matter file-to address

A recipient-alias rung that parses To/Cc/Bcc for matter-`{n}@` (or a provisioned per-record alias) and emits an explicit-reference-tier match. Reaches iManage/ND parity on the workspace-address pattern that clients' outbound systems rely on — with our confidence ladder layered on top.

Small

Extends: `new rung + NormalizedMessage (add Bcc)`

P1

NOW

Cross-mailbox dedupe

Add an `sprk_internetmessageid` existence check to the capture create-path. Closes the six-inbox duplication that NetDocuments explicitly guards against. The field is already captured; this is wiring, not new plumbing.

Small

Extends: `IncomingCommunicationProcessor`

P2

NEXT

Engine suggestions inside Outlook

Surface the engine's top-3 candidates in the "Save to Spaarke" task pane (and finish the stubbed one-click ribbon quick-save). Turns our add-in into true Predictive Filing and unifies it with the code-page review — one ranked candidate model everywhere.

Medium

Reuses: `derivePrimaryReview`

P2

NEXT

Optional send-time nudge

A `LaunchEvents OnMessageSend SoftBlock` that offers a filing destination on compose — strictly opt-in, never blocking. Lower priority than for the incumbents because capture-first means an unfiled email is never lost; it's a review-queue item, not a black hole.

Medium

Extends: `Outlook add-in manifest`

P3

LATER

Unified Recent + AI Suggested Locations

Replace the add-in's session-local recents with a server-backed, AI-ranked destination list shared across Outlook, the form and the code page — the "likely places this belongs" picker, powered by the engine rather than the user's last ten clicks.

Medium

P3

LATER

Optional Outlook-category mapping

For firms that want folder-mapping muscle-memory, map an Outlook category/folder to a regarding record as a deterministic signal into the engine — the habit without the taxonomy drift.

Small



ENABLER

Light up content-based attachment matching

The attachment→document rung (3.7) already queries `sprk_globalsearchextender` for distinctive keywords — it's wired but dormant until that field is populated. Populating it (the "augment global Document search" effort) unlocks matching by document *content*, not just filename, with no engine change.

Already wired: `AttachmentDocumentAssociationRung`

Grounded in the current codebase: capture via `GraphSubscriptionManager`; the rung engine + `AssociationStatusMapper` confidence ladder (Resolved / Suggested / Ambiguous / Pending Review); `ParticipantCorrelationRung`, `ThreadContinuityRung`, `AttachmentDocumentAssociationRung`; the `CommunicationConnections` / `EmailConnectionsReview` surfaces; and the Outlook add-in under `src/client/office-addins/outlook`. Competitor behavior per the supplied write-up (iManage, NetDocuments/ndMail, Worldox, ZERO) plus public documentation.

Prepared for the Email & Communication Intelligence UAT review — the intent is parity where clients expect it and a clear lead where the architecture already gives us one.